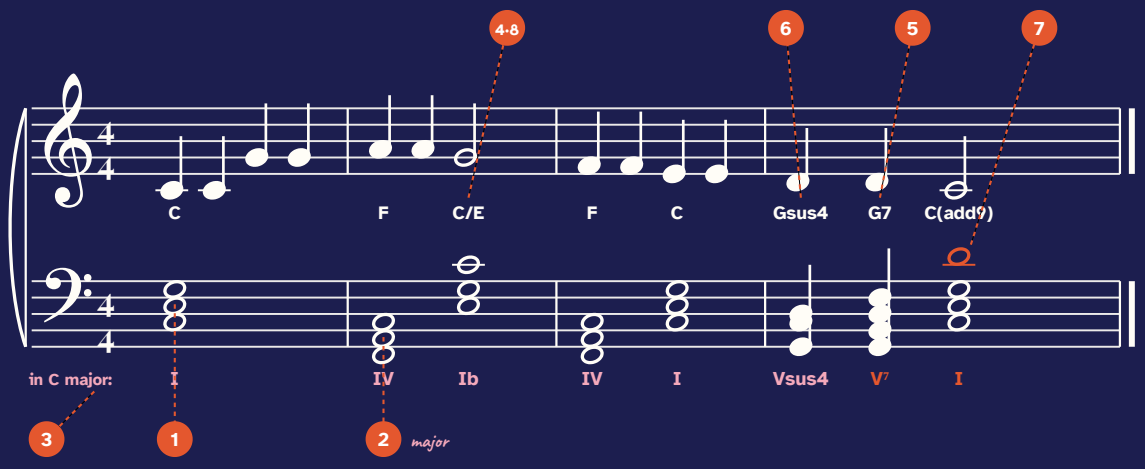
PART V · BUILD THEM

Chords

Press three notes at once and you have a chord. Stack them, name them, turn them upside down, add layers on top. Every chapter of this part is in these four bars of Twinkle.



1 **Chords and triads** p. 107
three notes stacked like a layer cake

2 **Four kinds of triad** p. 110
major 3 + 2, minor 2 + 3

3 **Chords in a key** p. 113
Roman numerals: I, IV and V do most of the work

4 **Inversions** p. 116
the same notes, a different one at the bottom

5 **Seventh chords** p. 119
one more layer on top: G7

6 **Colour chords** p. 122
sus and add: a note moved or added

7 **The tower: 9, 11, 13** p. 125
keep skipping a letter

8 **Slash chords** p. 128
C/E: the chord, then the bass note

★ **Tips: when a chord sounds wrong** p. 131

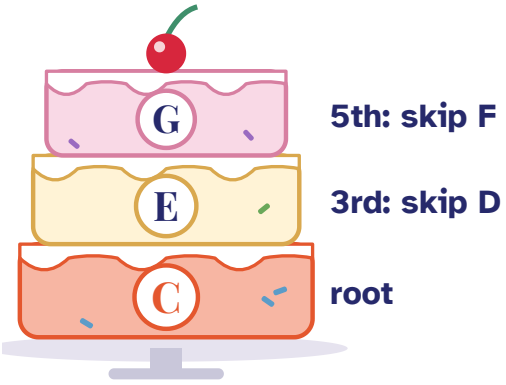
PART V · CHORDS · 1

Chords and triads

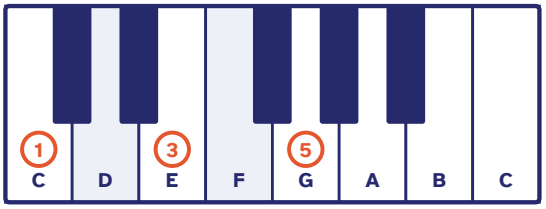
Press three or more notes at once and you have a **chord**. The favourite of all is the **triad**: three notes stacked like a layer cake.

THE SECRET

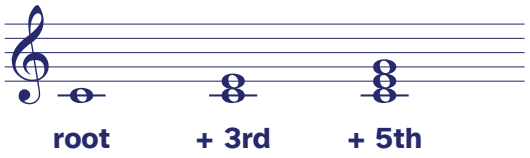
Play one, skip one, play one: the cake rule.



1. Pick a note: the **root**, the big layer at the bottom. It holds the chord up and gives it its name.
2. Skip one letter, take the next: **E**, the **3rd**.
3. Skip again: **G**, the **5th**. C E G is the triad of C.



On the keys: play one, skip one (shaded), play one, skip one, play one.



The cake on the staff: three lines in a row (or three spaces).

On the staff, each layer sits on the **next line up** (or the next space up): the root, a **3rd** above it, a **5th** above the root.

First met: Level ½ (the tonic triad of C, G and F major).

All lines or all spaces

A stacked triad sits on **three lines in a row** or in **three spaces in a row**, in a neat stack. If one note breaks the pattern, it is not a stacked triad.



Lines, spaces, lines, spaces: every one a triad.

PART V · CHORDS · 1 · CONTINUED

Solid and broken

Played together, a chord is **solid** (or blocked). Played one note at a time, it is **broken**. Spread up and down the keyboard, a broken chord becomes an **arpeggio**. Left-hand accompaniments, the arpeggios in technical work and the chord names over a song are all triads.

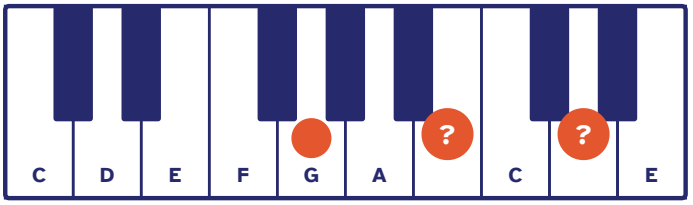
First met: Level 0; arpeggios from Level 1.



The same three notes, solid then broken.

EXAMPLE 1

Build a triad on G

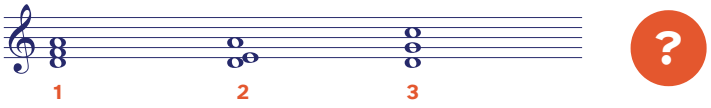


1. **Start on G** (the red dot): the root, the bottom layer.
2. **Skip one white key,** take the next: the first ?.
3. **Skip again,** take the next: the second ?.

G **B D**: the triad of **G**. Same shape as C E G, just moved up.

EXAMPLE 2

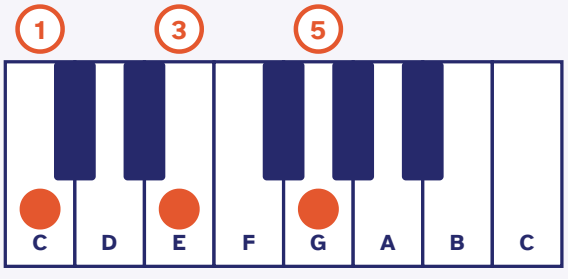
Which one is a triad?



1. **Look at each chord:** are the three notes all on lines, or all in spaces?
2. **Count the notes** from each note to the next one up: is every gap a 3rd?
3. **Only one chord** passes both tests. Which?

Chord 1 (D F A, three spaces in a row). Chord 2 has a 2nd (D–E); chord 3 is stacked in 4ths.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Thumb on C. Fingers 1, 3, 5 down together.

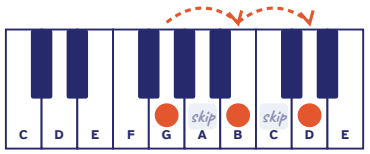
That is the C chord. Slide your hand to any white key and do it again: the cake shape always works.

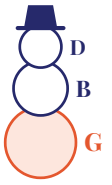
PART V · CHORDS · 1 · CONTINUED

GAME

Build one yourself

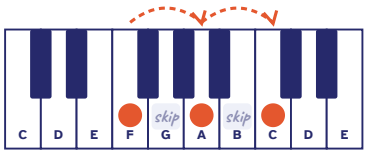
G

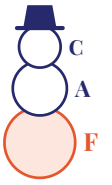




Start on G: **G B D**.

F

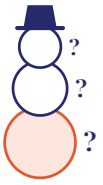




Start on F: **F A C**.
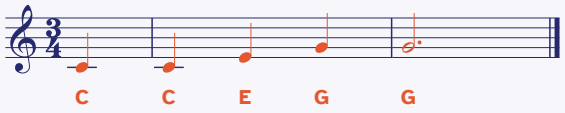
?





Your turn: start on **A**. Which three keys?

Build the cake on A: play one, skip one, play one, skip one, play one.

Answer: A C E: the triad on A.

YOU KNOW THIS

The Blue Danube (Johann Strauss II), here in C



The most famous waltz tune simply climbs the **C triad**: **C, C E G, G**. Root, 3rd, 5th, then it holds the top: that is why it sounds so open.

Try it. Play C E G one at a time, then hum the waltz over it.

THINK OF IT Solid: three friends shout “Hello!” together. Broken: each says it in turn.

TRAP

- × Stacking 2nds or 4ths: a triad skips exactly one letter each time.
- × Naming a chord from its top note: the root names it (at the bottom when the notes are stacked in 3rds).

SEE ALSO
Counting intervals p. 39 · Major scales p. 90

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Harmony 1 · Online: Library › Chords

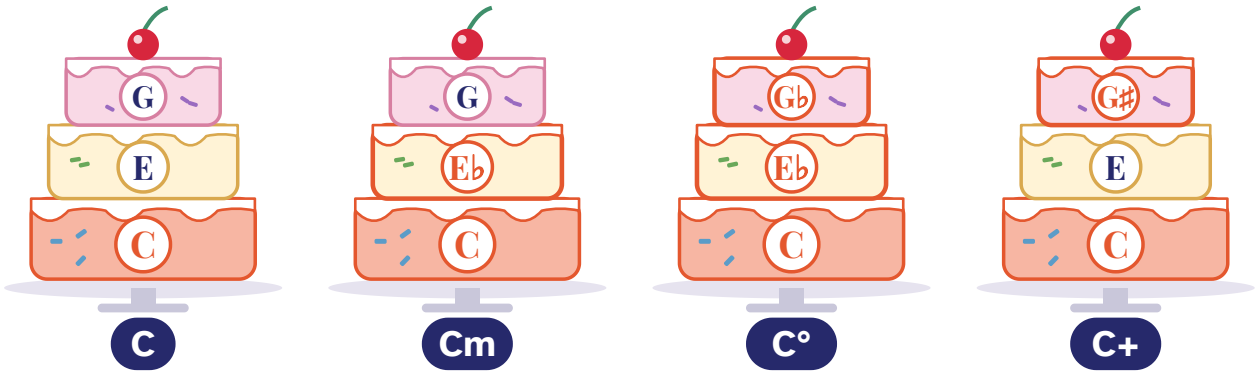
PART V · CHORDS · 2

Four kinds of triad

Every triad is two 3rds stacked. To tell the kinds apart, count the keys **in between**, black and white, that you do not play: root to 3rd, then 3rd to 5th. Those two numbers name the kind, and its sound.

THE SECRET

Count the keys between: 3 + 2 is major, 2 + 3 is minor.

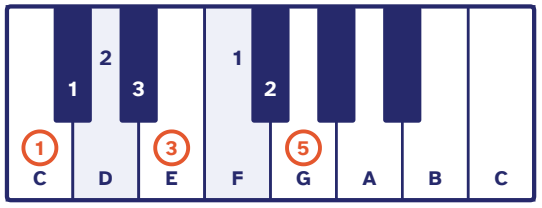


Count the keys between: 3 + 2 is major, 2 + 3 is minor

KIND	KEYS BETWEEN	ON C	CHORD NAME	FIRST MET
major	**3 + 2**	C E G	C	Level ½
minor	**2 + 3**	C E♭ G	Cm	Level 2
diminished	**2 + 2**	C E♭ G♭	C° or Cdim	Level 5
augmented	**3 + 3**	C E G♯	C+ or Caug	Level 6

Chord names: a letter alone means major (C); m means minor (Cm). You see them above the melody in songbooks and lead sheets: C | Am | F | G. In interval names, 3 keys between is a major 3rd and 2 is a minor 3rd (p. 42).

Count the keys in between



Play C and E and count the keys you skip, black and white: C♯, D, D♯ is **3**. Then E to G: F, F♯ is **2**. **3 + 2 is major.** Any root works the same way: from D, skip 3 to F♯, then 2 to A: D F♯ A, D major.

PART V · CHORDS · 2 · CONTINUED

The seven white-key triads, sorted



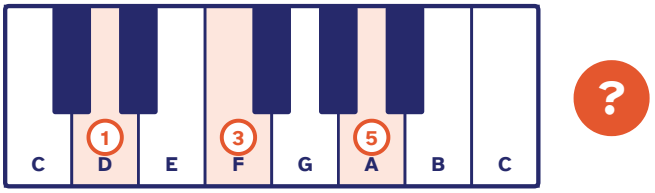
Always the same on the white keys: **three major** (C, F, G), **three minor** (D, E, A), **one diminished** (B), no augmented. Which ones belong to a key is the next chapter (p. 113).

How they sound

KIND	SOUNDS	HEARD IN
major	bright, settled, open	most cheerful tunes, fanfares
minor	darker, softer, sadder	lullabies, laments, film tension
diminished	tense, unstable, wants to move	suspense, spooky scenes
augmented	floating, dreamy, unsettled	dream scenes, a passing colour

EXAMPLE 1

Major or minor? D F A



1. **Root to 3rd:** count the keys between D and F, black and white.
2. **3rd to 5th:** count the keys between F and A.
3. **3 + 2 or 2 + 3?**

D to F has 2 between, F to A has 3: **2 + 3**, so D F A is **D minor** (Dm).

GAME

Which kind?

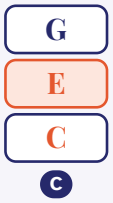
1	2	3
G♭	A	B♯
E♭	F♯	G♯
C	D	E

Count the keys between: 3 + 2 major, 2 + 3 minor, 2 + 2 diminished, 3 + 3 augmented.

Answer: 1 diminished · 2 major · 3 augmented.

PART V · CHORDS · 2 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

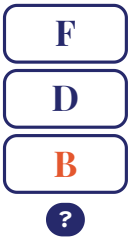


C E G, then C E♭ G, then C E♭ G♭.

Bright, dark, tense. Only the middle layer moves first, then the top one. Listen for the change each time.

EXAMPLE 2

What kind is the triad on B?
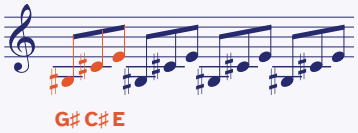


1. **Skip a letter:** B, D, F.
2. **Count the keys between** B and D, then D and F.
3. **Which kind has those two numbers?**

2 + 2: B D F is **B diminished** (B°), the only diminished triad on the white keys.

YOU KNOW THIS

Beethoven, Moonlight Sonata (first movement)



The famous slow triplets are the notes of a **C♯ minor triad**: C♯, E and G♯, rocking gently. Minor is why it sounds so dark and sad.

THINK OF IT Two gaps in the cake: a wide one (3 keys between) and a narrow one (2). Major: wide, then narrow, 3 + 2. Minor: narrow, then wide, 2 + 3. Diminished: two narrow, 2 + 2. Augmented: two wide, 3 + 3.

TRAP

- × Counting the keys you play: count only the keys in between, black and white.
- × Forgetting that in diminished and augmented triads the 5th changes too.
- × Spelling with the wrong letter: a triad skips one letter, so C minor is C E♭ G, never C D♯ G.

SEE ALSO

Chords and triads p. 107 · Major, minor and perfect p. 42

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 2 · Online: Library › Chords

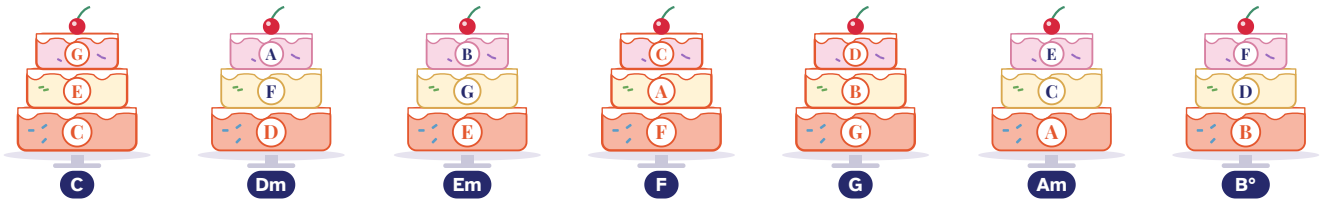
PART V · CHORDS · 3

Chords in a key
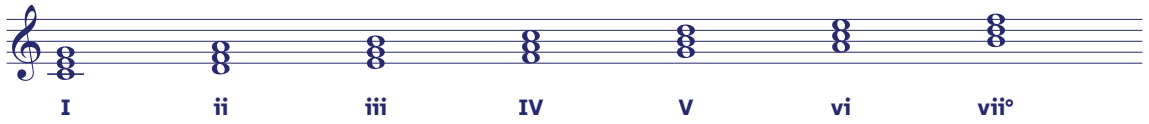
Build a triad on every note of a scale and you have the chords of that key. **Roman numerals** name each one by its place in the scale: I on the 1st note, IV on the 4th, V on the 5th. Capitals are major, small numerals are minor, and small with ° is diminished.

THE SECRET

Build a cake on every note of the scale: I, IV and V are the strongest.



One cake on every note: I, IV and V do most of the work



The seven chords of C major. Only white keys, so the kinds come out as on p. 111.

NUMERAL	NAME	KIND	KEYS BETWEEN	IN C	IN G
I	tonic	major	3 + 2	C	G
ii	supertonic	minor	2 + 3	Dm	Am
iii	mediant	minor	2 + 3	Em	Bm
IV	subdominant	major	3 + 2	F	C
V	dominant	major	3 + 2	G	D
vi	submediant	minor	2 + 3	Am	Em
vii°	leading note	diminished	2 + 2	B°	F♯°

The same in every major key: I, IV and V are major; ii, iii and vi are minor; vii° is diminished. First met: I, IV and V at Levels 1–2; the other chords from about Level 4.

The three primary chords
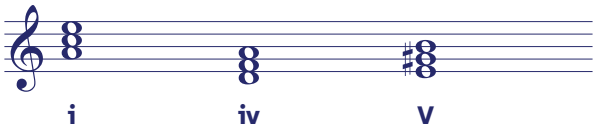
I, IV and V are the strongest chords of a key. Between them they hold **every note of the scale**: C E G, F A C, G B D. That is why so many tunes need only these three.

THINK OF IT I is the key's own chord. IV and V are its two big neighbours. Between the three of them, every note of the scale has a chord to sit in.

PART V · CHORDS · 3 · CONTINUED

In a minor key

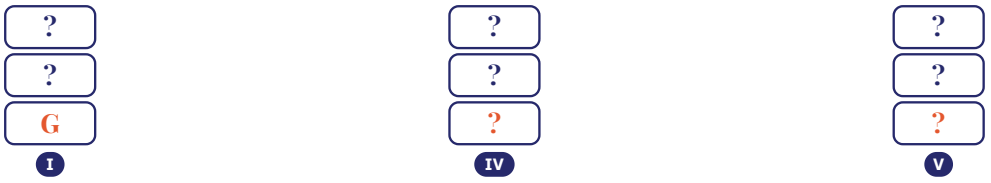
In A minor the three main chords are **i** (A minor), **iv** (D minor) and **V**: E G♯ B, made major by the **raised 7th** of the harmonic minor (p. 93), G♯. Check: E G♯ B is 3 + 2, major.



A minor: i, iv and V. The G♯ makes V major.

EXAMPLE 1

Find I, IV and V in G major



1. **Count up the scale** from G: which notes are 1st, 4th and 5th?
2. **Build a cake on each,** using the key signature (one sharp: F♯).
3. **Check the keys between:** are all three 3 + 2?

In G major: **I = G** (G B D), **IV = C** (C E G), **V = D** (D F♯ A), all major.

GAME

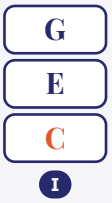
Which numeral?



All in C major. Count up the scale from C to find each chord's number.

Answer: 1 IV · 2 V · 3 vi · 4 ii.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



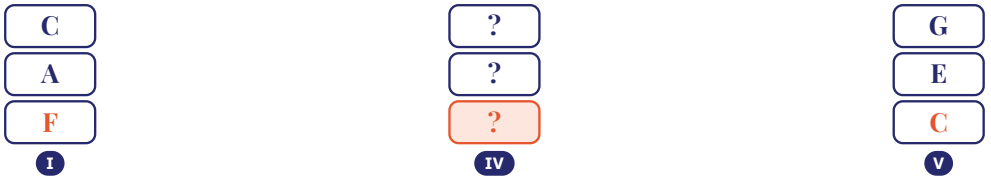
Left hand: C, F, G.

Play the cakes of I, IV and V in C major, then sing any nursery tune over them: these three fit almost every note.

PART V · CHORDS · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Find IV in F major



1. **Count up the scale** from F to the 4th note. Watch the key signature: one flat.
2. **Build the cake** on that note.
3. **Check the keys between.**

IV in F major is **B♭**: B♭ D F, 3 + 2, major.

EXAMPLE 3

Find V in D minor



1. **The 5th note** of D minor is A: build A C E.
2. **The 7th note** of the D minor scale is C. In the harmonic minor it is raised: to what?
3. **Put it in the middle layer.** What kind is the chord now?

C becomes **C♯**: V in D minor is A C♯ E, **A major**.

EXAMPLE 4

The chord on note 6 of C major



1. **Build the cake on A:** skip one, take the next, twice.
2. **Count the keys between:** major or minor?
3. **Note 6 of the scale:** which numeral, capital or small?

A C E, 2 + 3: **A minor**, numeral **vi** (small, because it is minor).

TRAP

- × Writing every numeral big: ii, iii and vi are minor, so they are written small.
- × Forgetting the raised 7th in a minor key: V in A minor is E G♯ B, not E G B.

SEE ALSO

Four kinds of triad p. 110 · Major scales p. 90 · Inversions p. 116

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 3 · Online: Library › Chords

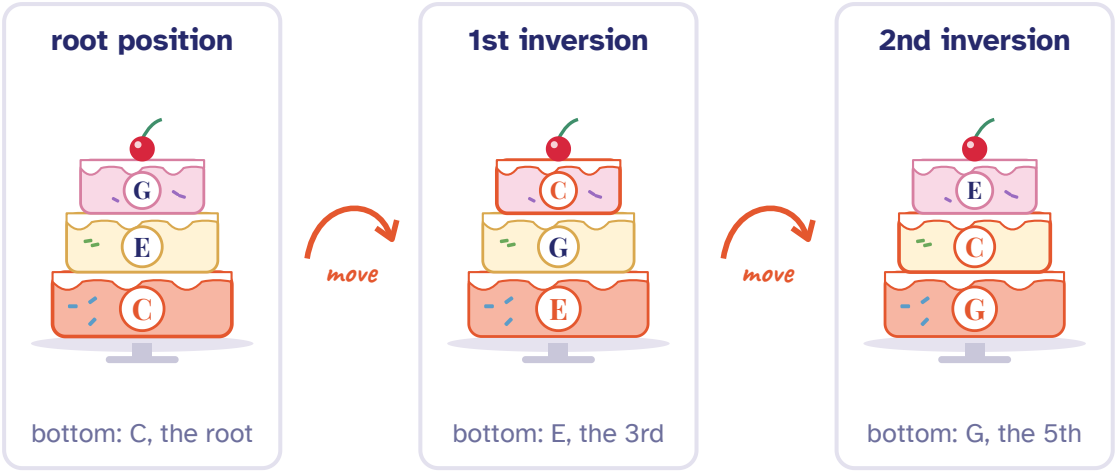
PART V · CHORDS · 4

Inversions
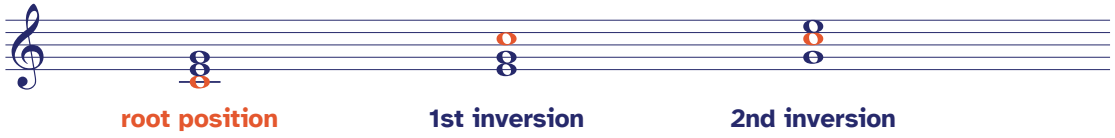
Same three notes, a different one at the bottom. The chord keeps its name; only the bass changes. The red layer is the root, C: watch it travel.

THE SECRET

Move the bottom note to the top: same chord, new bass.



1. Start with the cake **C E G**: root at the bottom.
2. Move the bottom layer to the top: **E G C**. That is the 1st inversion.
3. Move it again: **G C E**, the 2nd inversion. Still **C major**.



The same three chords on the staff; the red note is the root, C. To find the root, restack the notes every other letter (like C E G): then the bottom layer is the root.

Why inversions?

They let your hand **move as little as possible**: keep any note two chords share, and move the others to the nearest note of the next chord. Left-hand accompaniments and hymn parts are written this way.

GAME

Which position?

1	2	3
C E G	E G C	G C E

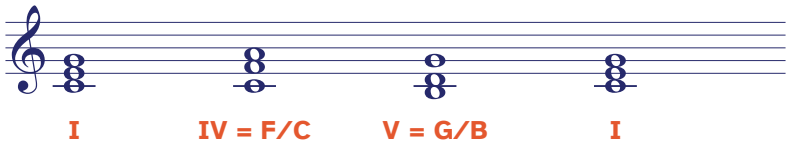
Same three notes. Look at the bottom one: root, 3rd or 5th?

Answer: 1 root position · 2 first inversion (E at the bottom) · 3 second inversion (G at the bottom).

PART V · CHORDS · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Move as little as possible: C, F, G, C



1. **I:** C E G. **IV:** keep C, move E up to F and G up to A: C F A.
2. **V:** no shared note. C steps down to B, F down to D, A down to G: B D G.
3. **I again:** B up to C, D up to E, G stays: C E G.

F stands on C, G stands on B: **inversions** keep the hand in one place.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Climb the chord.

Play C E G, then E G C, then G C E, then C E G an octave up. Same cake, changing its bottom layer as it climbs.

EXAMPLE 2

Write F major in first inversion



1. **Build F major** in root position first.
2. **First inversion:** which layer goes to the bottom, the 3rd or the 5th?
3. **Stack the other two** above it, in order.

The 3rd, A, goes to the bottom: **A C F**.

EXAMPLE 3

Find the second inversion of G



1. **Build G major:** skip one, take the next, from G.
2. **Second inversion:** the 5th goes to the bottom.
3. **Stack the other two** above it.

The 5th, D, at the bottom: **D G B**.

PART V · CHORDS · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

Find the root of E G C



1. **Restack the notes** so that each skips one letter: try starting on each note.
2. **Which order works?** C E G, E G C or G C E?
3. **The bottom layer** of that stack is the root.

C E G works: the root is **C**. E G C is C major, 1st inversion.

EXAMPLE 5

Which position? A D F
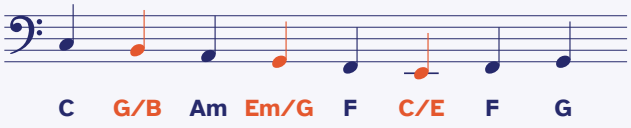


1. **Restack it** so each note skips one letter.
2. **Find the root** (the bottom layer of the stack) and the kind.
3. **Which layer is at the bottom** of A D F: root, 3rd or 5th?

Restacked: D F A, **D minor**. A, the 5th, is at the bottom: **2nd inversion**.

YOU KNOW THIS

Pachelbel's Canon, the bass (here in C)



In the popular version the bass walks **straight down the scale**: C B A G F E. It can, because some chords are **inversions**: G stands on B, Em on G, C on E.

Try it. Play the bass slowly and hum the famous violin tune over it.

TRAP

- × Naming a chord from its bass note: in an inversion the bass is not the root. Restack it in 3rds first.
- × Thinking an inversion is a new chord: E G C is still C major.

SEE ALSO

Chords and triads p. 107 · Chords in a key p. 113 · Slash chords p. 128

PRACTISE IT

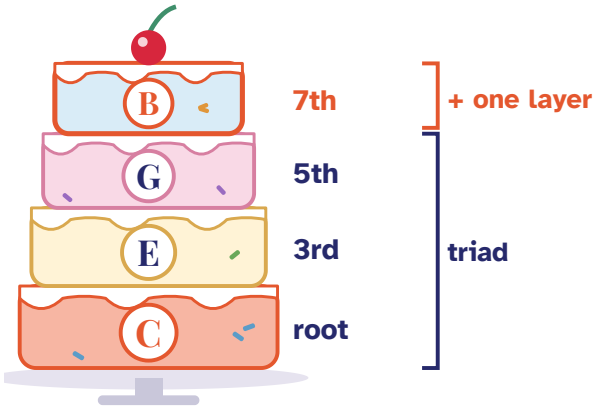
Workbook Harmony 4 · Online: Library › Chords

PART V · CHORDS · 5

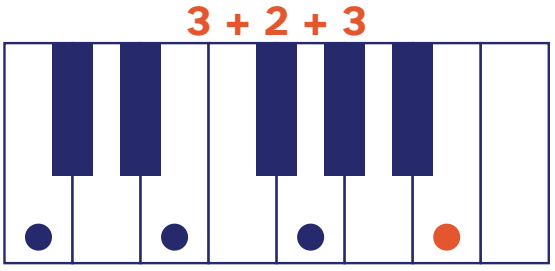
Seventh chords

Add one more layer to the cake and the chord changes colour: dreamy, bluesy, spooky. Same rule as before: skip one note, stack the next. The new note is the **7th**.

THE SECRET
One more layer on the cake and the chord changes colour.



1. Build the triad: **C E G**.
2. Skip one, add the next: **B**.
3. Count the keys between: **3 + 2 + 3**. That is **Cmaj7**.
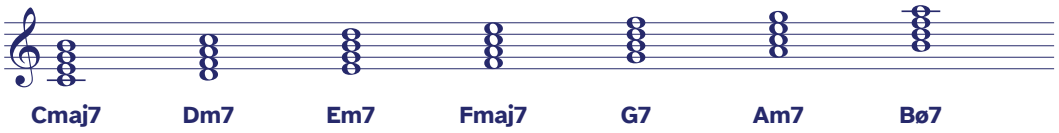


Five flavours, all on C

Cmaj7	C7	Cm7	Cø7	C°7
3 + 2 + 3	3 + 2 + 2	2 + 3 + 2	2 + 2 + 3	2 + 2 + 2
C E G B	C E G B♭	C E♭ G B♭	C E♭ G♭ B♭	C E♭ G♭ B𝄫
dreamy	**bluesy**	**mellow**	**searching**	**spooky**
bossa nova, film	the blues	soul, jazz ballads	jazz, film noir	old film villains

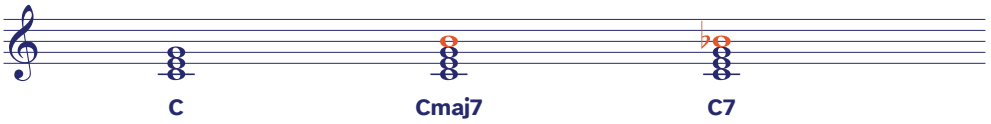
How the names work: major triad + major 7th = **maj7** · major triad + minor 7th = **7** · minor triad + minor 7th = **m7** · diminished triad + minor 7th = **ø7** · diminished triad + diminished 7th = **°7**.

A seventh on every note of C major



Only white keys: count the keys between to name each one.

PART V · CHORDS · 5 · CONTINUED

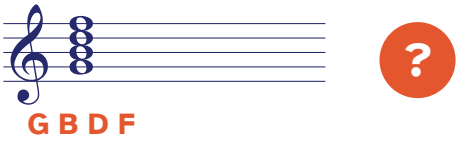


One note decides: B makes Cmaj7, B♭ makes C7. Everything below stays the same.

Spot the difference

EXAMPLE 1

Which seventh is it? G B D F



1. **Count the keys between** each layer: G to B, B to D, D to F.
2. **Which of the five flavours** has those three numbers?
3. **The root is G.** Name the chord.

3 + 2 + 2, the bluesy one, on G: **G7**.

GAME

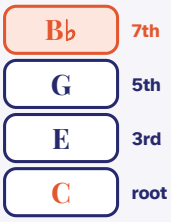
Which seventh?

1	2	3
F A C E	C E G B♭	D F A C

A cake with one more layer. Name each chord.

Answer: 1 Fmaj7 · 2 C7 · 3 Dm7.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Play C7, then Cmaj7.

C E G B♭, then C E G B. One key changes the top layer: bluesy, then dreamy.

PART V · CHORDS · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Cmaj7 or C7: which note changes?

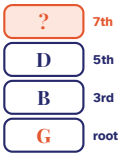


1. **Both start with C major:** C E G.
2. **Compare the top layers.** Which one note is different?
3. **Count the keys between** G and the top layer in each.

Only the top layer changes: **B** (3 between) is Cmaj7, **B♭** (2 between) is C7.

EXAMPLE 3

Build G7

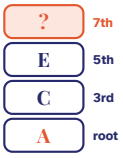


1. **Build G major:** G B D.
2. **Skip one more letter** above D: which?
3. **Count the keys between** D and it: 2 (the bluesy 7) or 3 (maj7)?

G B D **F**: 3 + 2 + 2, so it is **G7**.

EXAMPLE 4

Build Am7



1. **Build A minor:** A C E (2 + 3).
2. **Add the next letter** but one above E.
3. **Count the keys between** E and the new layer.

A C E **G**: 2 + 3 + 2, so it is **Am7**.

TRAP

- × Writing C7 when you mean Cmaj7: "7" alone means the bluesy one, with B♭.
- × Stacking the 7th from the wrong note: count a 7th up from the root, not from the 5th.

SEE ALSO
Four kinds of triad p. 110 · Chords in a key p. 113

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Harmony 5 · Online: Library › Chords

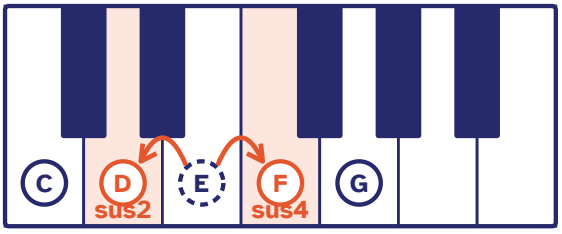
PART V · CHORDS · 6

Colour chords

The 3rd is the chord's mood: major or minor, happy or sad. Slide it aside, take it away, or add one note, and a plain chord takes on a new colour. Five colours, all from C E G.

THE SECRET

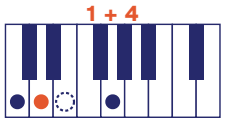
Move the 3rd, take it away, or add one note: five new colours.



1. Start from **C E G**. The **E** (the 3rd) makes it major.
2. Slide the E up to the next letter, **F**: **Csus4**.
3. Or down to the letter below, **D**: **Csus2**. With no 3rd, the chord is neither major nor minor: it **hangs in the air**.

Five colours, all on C

Csus2

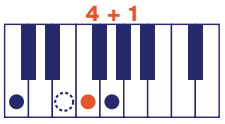


C D G

open

the 3rd steps down

Csus4

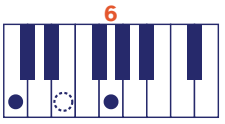


C F G

floating

the 3rd steps up

C5

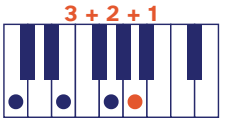


C G

strong

no 3rd at all

C6

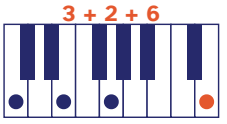


C E G A

warm

add the 6th

Cadd9

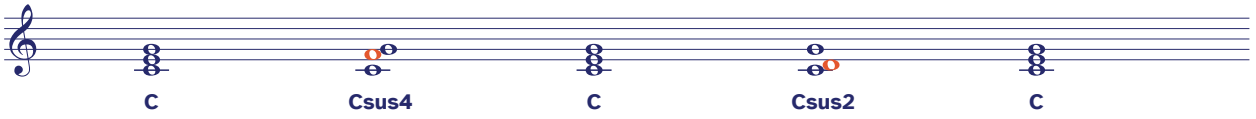


C E G D

sparkly

add the 9th on top

Lean, then slide back



The red note leans, then slides back to E: F steps down, D steps up. Play it slowly: C, Csus4, C, Csus2, C. Guitarists love this shimmer.

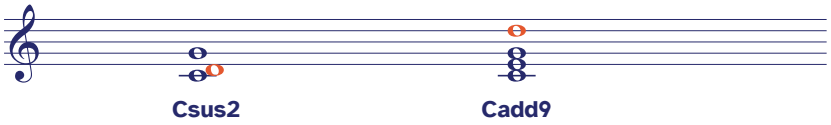
On any root, the counts stay the same

COLOUR	KEYS BETWEEN	ON C	ON G	ON F	ON D
sus2	1 + 4	C D G	G A D	F G C	D E A
sus4	4 + 1	C F G	G C D	F B♭ C	D G A
5	6	C G	G D	F C	D A
6	3 + 2 + 1	C E G **A**	G B D **E**	F A C **D**	D F♯ A **B**
add9	3 + 2 + 6	C E G **D**	G B D **A**	F A C **G**	D F♯ A **E**

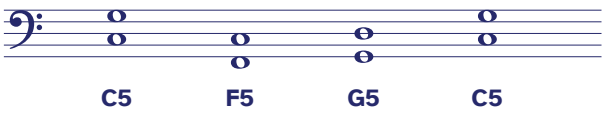
PART V · CHORDS · 6 · CONTINUED

sus: the 3rd held up or down · **5**: no 3rd at all · **6** and **add9**: one note added on top. Csus means Csus4.

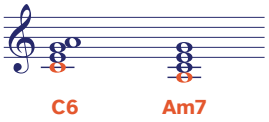
Spot the difference



The same red D, two jobs. Csus2 throws the E out; Cadd9 keeps the E and puts the D on top.



The power chord: just the root and the 5th, played low in the left hand. With no 3rd it is neither happy nor sad, only **strong**: the sound of rock guitar. Play C5, F5, G5, C5 and drum the rhythm.



C6 or Am7? The same four notes, C E G A. The red bottom note decides: C at the bottom is **C6**; A at the bottom is **Am7**. More on the bass note in Slash chords, p. 128.

EXAMPLE 1

Which colour is it? G C D



1. **Count the keys between:** G to C, then C to D.
2. **Find the card** with the same two numbers.
3. **Is there a 3rd (B)?** What has taken its place?

4 + 1, no B: G C D is **Gsus4**. Swap the C for **B** and you have G major.

GAME

sus2, sus4 or add9?

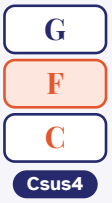
1	2	3
C D G	C F G	C E G D

In a sus chord the 3rd has moved; in an add chord nothing moved and a note was added.

Answer: 1 Csus2 · 2 Csus4 · 3 Cadd9.

PART V · CHORDS · 6 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

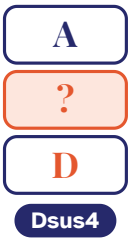


Csus4, then C.

Play C F G, then C E G. No 3rd, then a 3rd: floating, then bright.

EXAMPLE 2

Build Dsus4

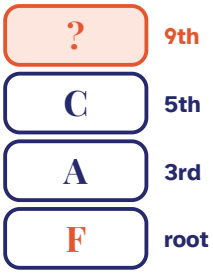


1. **Start with D major:** D F♯ A.
2. **sus4:** move the middle layer up to the next letter.
3. **Which key is it?**

F♯ moves up to **G**: Dsus4 is **D G A**.

EXAMPLE 3

Build Fadd9



1. **Start with F major:** F A C, and keep every note.
2. **The 9th** is the 2nd, an octave up: which letter comes just after F?
3. **Put it on top.**

Fadd9: F A C **G**. Nothing moved; one note was added.

THINK OF IT Decorating the cake: a ribbon (the 6th) or a candle (the 9th) and it is still the same cake. Sus moves its middle layer; a power chord takes the middle layer out.

TRAP

× Calling Cadd9 a ninth chord: C9 also has the 7th (B♭). Add9 is just the triad plus the 9th (D on C), nothing else (The tower, p. 125).

SEE ALSO
Four kinds of triad p. 110 · Seventh chords p. 119

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Harmony 6 · Online: Library › Chords

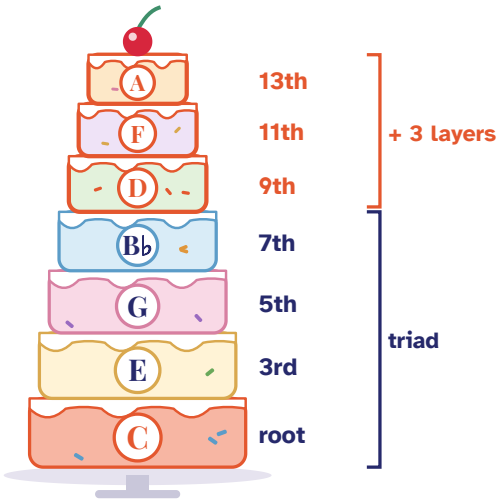
PART V · CHORDS · 7

The tower: 9, 11, 13

Why stop at the 7th? Keep stacking 3rds and the cake grows three more layers: the 9th, the 11th and the 13th. At the top you have used **all seven letters, A to G**.

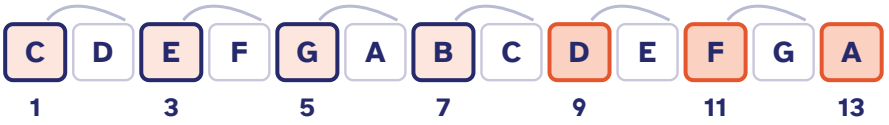
THE SECRET

Keep skipping letters above the 7th: 9, 11, 13 are 2, 4, 6 an octave up.



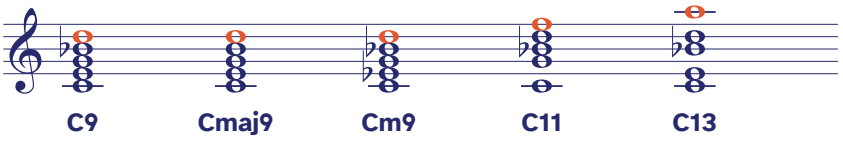
1. Build the seventh chord: **C E G B♭** (C7).
2. Keep skipping one letter: **D**, **F**, **A**. Those layers are the **9th, 11th and 13th**.
3. Take 7 away to find the letter: 9 → 2nd (D), 11 → 4th (F), 13 → 6th (A). Same letters, an octave up.

Skip a letter, all the way up



Start on C and take every other letter: C E G B D F A (letters only: in C7 the B is B♭). After the 13th comes C again: the tower is full.

Five tall chords on C

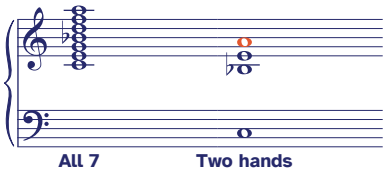


The red note is the top layer that gives each chord its name. C11 and C13 leave some notes out: see p. 126.

CHORD	BUILT AS	NOTES	SOUNDS	HEARD IN
C9	C7 + 9th	C E G B♭ **D**	soulful	funk, soul
Cmaj9	Cmaj7 + 9th	C E G B **D**	dreamy	film, ballads
Cm9	Cm7 + 9th	C E♭ G B♭ **D**	smooth	neo-soul, R&B
C11	C9 + 11th, no 3rd	C G B♭ D **F**	airy	gospel, pop
C13	C7 + 13th	C E B♭ (D) **A**	rich	jazz, blues endings

PART V · CHORDS · 7 · CONTINUED

Too many notes? Leave some out



All seven notes sound muddy. Two hands play C13 with four: C in the left hand, B♭ E A in the right.

Ten fingers, seven layers: you choose. **Keep** the 3rd and the 7th (they say what kind of chord it is) and the red top note (its colour). **Leave out** the 5th first. The right hand can drop the root too, when the left hand or a bass player plays it.

With a major 3rd, the 11th (F) rubs against E. So C13 leaves out the F. C11 does the opposite: it keeps the F and leaves out the E.

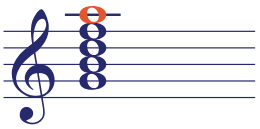
6 or 13? add9 or 9?

SAME TOP NOTE	WITHOUT THE 7TH	WITH THE 7TH (B♭)
A on C	**C6**: C E G A	**C13**: C E B♭ A
D on C	**Cadd9**: C E G D	**C9**: C E G B♭ D

Look for the 7th. No 7th: a colour chord (p. 122). A 7th: a tower chord.

EXAMPLE 1

Name this tall chord: G B D F A



G B D F A

?

1. **Find the root:** each note skips one letter, so the bottom note is the root.
2. **The first four layers:** count the keys between. Which seventh?
3. **The red top layer:** which number is it above G?

G7 (3 + 2 + 2) with A, the 9th, on top: **G9**.

GAME

Which floor?

1 — the 9th of C

2 — the 11th of C

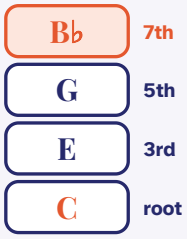
3 — the 13th of C

Build C7 (C E G B♭), then keep skipping one letter above the B♭.

Answer: 1 D · 2 F · 3 A.

PART V · CHORDS · 7 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

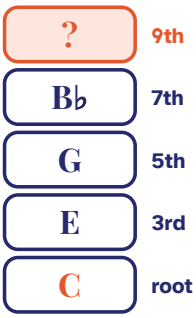


Play C7, then add one more.

Left hand C E G, right hand B♭, then add the next letter but one above it. You just built a tall chord.

EXAMPLE 2

Build C9



1. **Build C7:** C E G B♭.
2. **Skip one more letter** above B♭: which letter?
3. **Five notes:** share them between the hands if you need to.

C9: C E G B♭ **D**, one layer above the 7th.

HOW TO

Build any tall chord

1. **Start on the root** and skip one letter each time: 1 3 5 7 9 11 13.
2. **Stop** at the number in the name.
3. **Leave out** the 5th first; in a 13th chord, the 11th too, when it is too many notes for your hands.

THINK OF IT You don't need every layer. Keep the 3rd and the 7th, which say what kind of chord it is, and the top layer, which gives it its colour.

TRAP

- × Hunting far up for the 9th: it is just the 2nd, an octave higher (D on C).
- × Calling C13 a C6: the 13th chord has the 7th (B♭) as well.
- × Playing F and E together in C13 or C11: they clash. C13 drops the F; C11 drops the E.

SEE ALSO
Seventh chords p. 119 · Colour chords p. 122

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Harmony 7 · Online: Library › Chords

PART V · CHORDS · 8

Slash chords

C/E means one chord with a chosen bass note: play a C chord, with E as the lowest note. It is not a fraction, and not two chords.

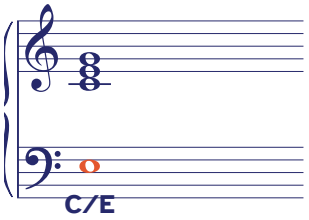
THE SECRET
Chord before the slash, bass note after it.

C/E

the chord
right hand

the bass
left hand, lowest note

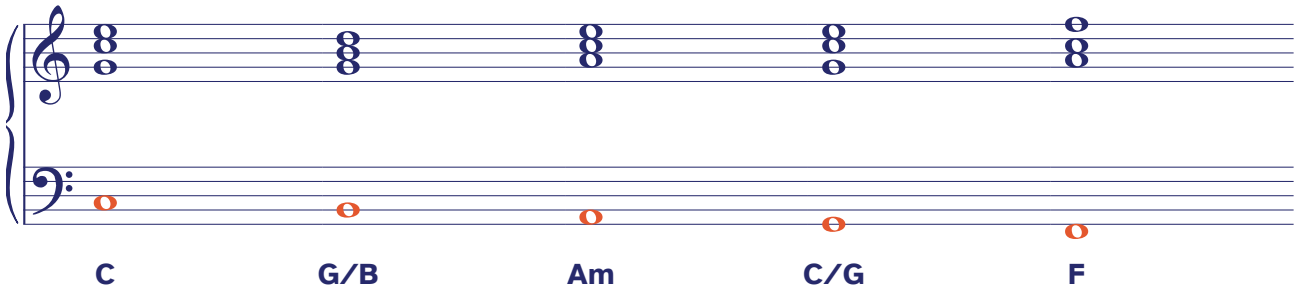
1. Before the slash: the **chord**. C means C E G, in the right hand.
2. After the slash: the **bass**. E goes in the left hand, below everything.
3. Play them together: **C/E**, “C over E”.



Four jobs for a slash chord

JOB	EXAMPLE	THE BASS NOTE IS	WHAT YOU HEAR
Inversion	C/E · C/G	a note of the chord	smoother changes (p. 116)
Walk-down	C · G/B · Am	one step down each time	a bass line that walks down
Pedal	F/C · G/C	the same note, held	the chords change above it
Colour	F/G · D/C	not in the chord	open, modern: pop, gospel

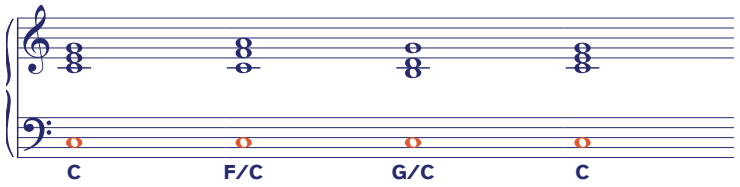
Job 2: a bass that walks down



The red bass walks straight down, C B A G F, while the right hand moves a step at most. G/B and C/G make the steps possible.

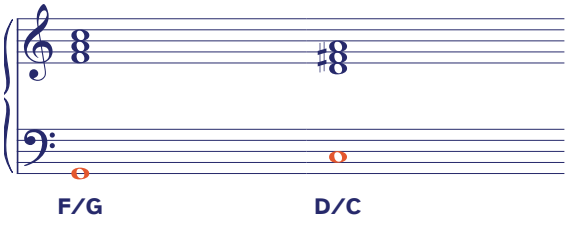
PART V · CHORDS · 8 · CONTINUED

Job 3: a pedal, one bass under everything



The bass holds C while the chords change above it: C, F/C, G/C, C. The chords change while the C stays. (It is called a pedal after the organ's foot pedals, which hold long low notes.)

Job 4: a bass from outside the chord

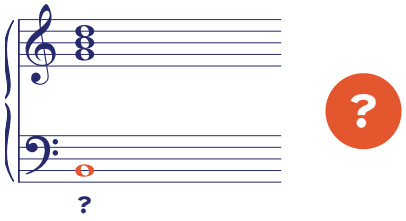


F/G: F A C over a G. G is not in the F chord, so it floats, open and unfinished. Pop and gospel players love it.

D/C: D F♯ A over a C. The C is not in the D chord, so it rubs against the chord.

EXAMPLE 1

Name the slash chord



1. **The right hand:** which chord is G B D?
2. **The lowest note:** which note is in the left hand?
3. **Write chord, slash, bass.** Is the bass in the chord?

It is **G/B**, "G over B": B is in the G chord, so it is the 1st inversion.

GAME

Read the slash

1	2	3	4
G/B	C/G	F/A	Am/C

Before the slash: the chord. After it: the bass note. Which note goes in the left hand?

Answer: 1 B · 2 G · 3 A · 4 C.

PART V · CHORDS · 8 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

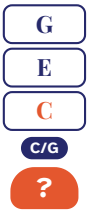


Right hand C, left hand E.

Play C E G in the right hand and a low E in the left: C/E. Now try a low A under it: what would you call that?

EXAMPLE 2

C/G: which note goes in the left hand?

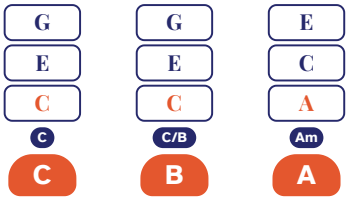


1. **Before the slash:** the chord. Which three notes go in the right hand?
2. **After the slash:** the bass. Which note goes low in the left hand?
3. **Play them together.**

Right hand C E G, left hand a low **G**: the C chord standing on G.

EXAMPLE 3

Walk the bass down: C, C/B, Am



1. **Right hand** holds C E G for two chords.
2. **Left hand** walks down: C, then B.
3. **Then A**, under A C E: Am.

The bass walks **C B A**, one step at a time, while the chords hardly move.

THINK OF IT A cake and the plate it stands on: the slash says which cake (the chord) and which plate (the bass). Same cake, new plate, new view.

TRAP

- × Writing it back to front: the chord comes first, the bass second. E/C would be an E chord over C.
- × Letting the right hand dip below the bass: the letter after the slash must be the lowest note you play.
- × Forgetting the chord itself: in C/E the right hand still plays the whole C chord, C E G, not just C.

SEE ALSO

Inversions p. 116 · Colour chords p. 122

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 8 · Online: Library › Chords

PART V · CHORDS · TIPS

When a chord sounds wrong

A chord that sounds wrong usually has one small slip. Name the slip, fix that one note, and the chord comes right.

TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
A chord sounds dark when it should be bright	**the kind**: keys between, 3 + 2 or 2 + 3	p. 110
Your hand jumps all over	**an inversion**: keep the shared note still	p. 116
A big chord sounds muddy	**leave notes out**: drop the 5th first	p. 125
A seventh chord sounds wrong	**the 7th**: G7 adds F, a 7th above G (9 keys between)	p. 119
A sus chord sounds unfinished	**the 4th**: the middle layer moved up a letter	p. 122
The bass note sounds odd	**the slash**: the letter after it is the lowest note	p. 128

Four ways to learn chords fast

1. **Build, then play**
   Say the cake (C E G) before your fingers go down.

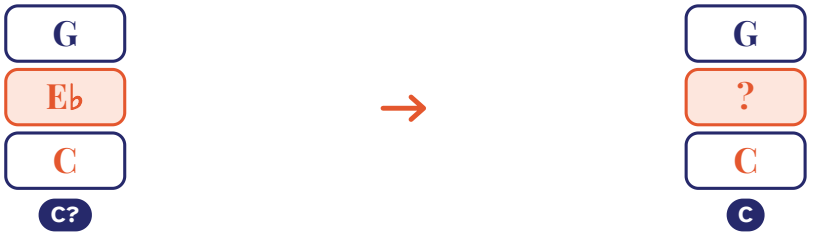
2. **Hands alone first**
   Left hand chords alone, then the tune alone, then together.

3. **One cake, three keys**
   Build the same kind of chord on C, G and F.

4. **Listen for the kind**
   Play major and minor side by side: bright, then dark.

EXAMPLE

Fix a dark chord



1. **It sounds dark**, but the music wants a bright C chord.
2. **Count the keys between:** C to E♭, then E♭ to G. Which kind is that?
3. **Move one note** so it becomes 3 + 2. Which layer, and to which key?

Move the middle layer from E♭ up to **E**: 3 + 2, bright C major again.

THINK OF IT Like a mechanic: one odd sound points to one part. Fix that part and the engine runs smoothly.